# Chapter 10: Project Communications Management

**Information Technology Project Management, Ninth Edition**

Note: See the text itself for full citations

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# Learning Objectives (1 of 2)

- Discuss the role of soft skills in IT project management, and highlight the importance of good communications as one means of achieving project success
- Review key concepts related to good communications
- Explain the elements of planning project communications and how to create a communications management plan
- Describe how to manage communications, including communication technologies, media, and performance reporting
- Discuss methods for controlling communications to ensure that information needs are met throughout the life of the project
- List various methods for improving project communications, such as running effective meetings, using various technologies effectively, and using templates

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# Learning Objectives (2 of 2)

- Describe how software can enhance project communications management
- Discuss considerations for agile/adaptive environments

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# The Importance of Project Communications Management

- Greatest threat to many projects is a failure to communicate
  - You cannot totally separate technical skills and soft skills when working on IT projects
  - For projects to succeed, every project team member needs both types of skills
- Project managers say they spend as much as 90 percent of their time communicating

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# Keys to Good Communications (1 of 2)

- Good communications consider size of the group, type of information, and appropriate communication medium
- Several important concepts can help
  - Focus on group and individual communication needs
    - Every person is unique, so you cannot simply generalize based on a personality profile or other traits
  - Use formal and informal methods for communicating
    - Many people prefer informal communications
    - Oral communication also helps build stronger relationships among project personnel and project stakeholders
  - Distribute important information in an effective and timely manner
    - Document any changes in technical specifications that might affect product performance
    - Report bad news
    - Have short, frequent meetings
  - Setting the stage for communicating bad news
    - Evaluate the impact of the situation
    - Consider alternatives
    - Make a recommendation to mitigate a problem

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# Keys to Good Communications (2 of 2)

- Several important concepts can help (cont.)
  - Determining the number of communication channels
    - Number of communications channels = $n(n\text{-}1)/2$, where $n$ is the number of people involved
      - Limit the size of teams to avoid making communications too complex

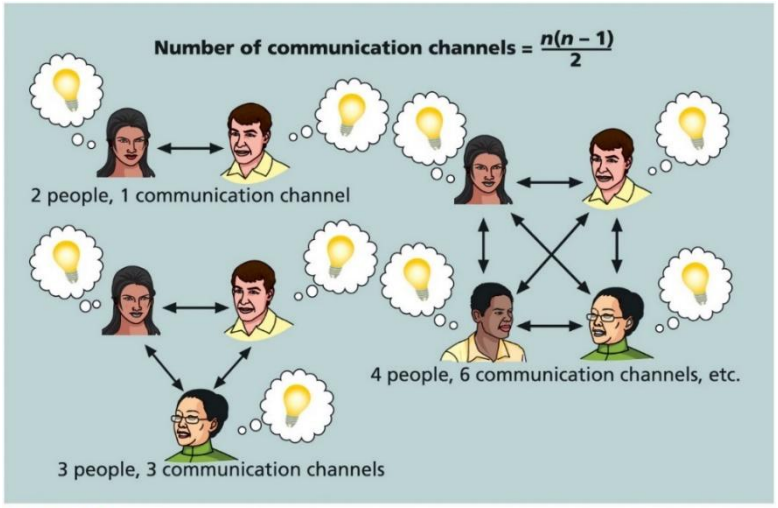
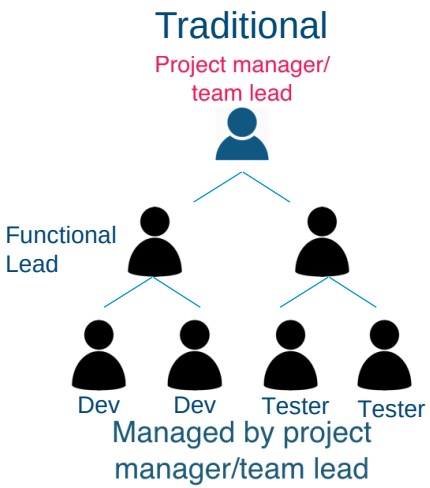
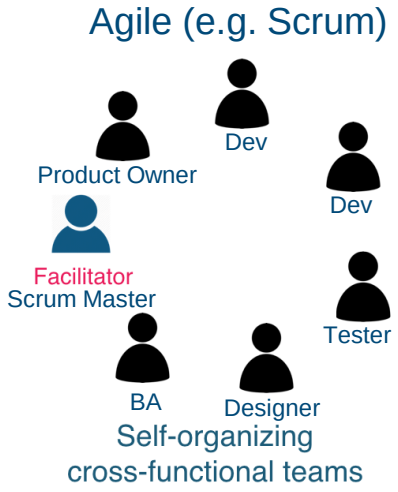
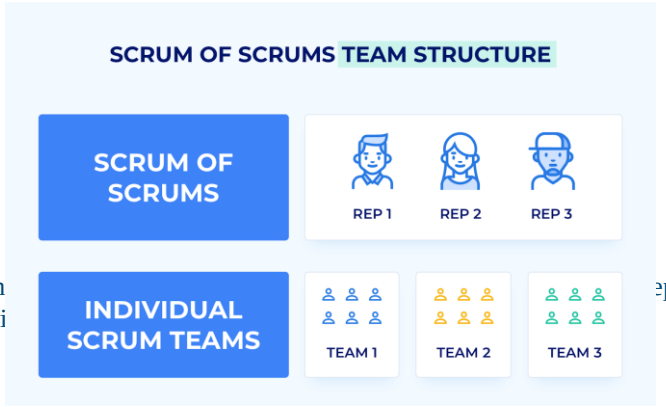



FIGURE 10-2 The impact of the number of people on communication channels



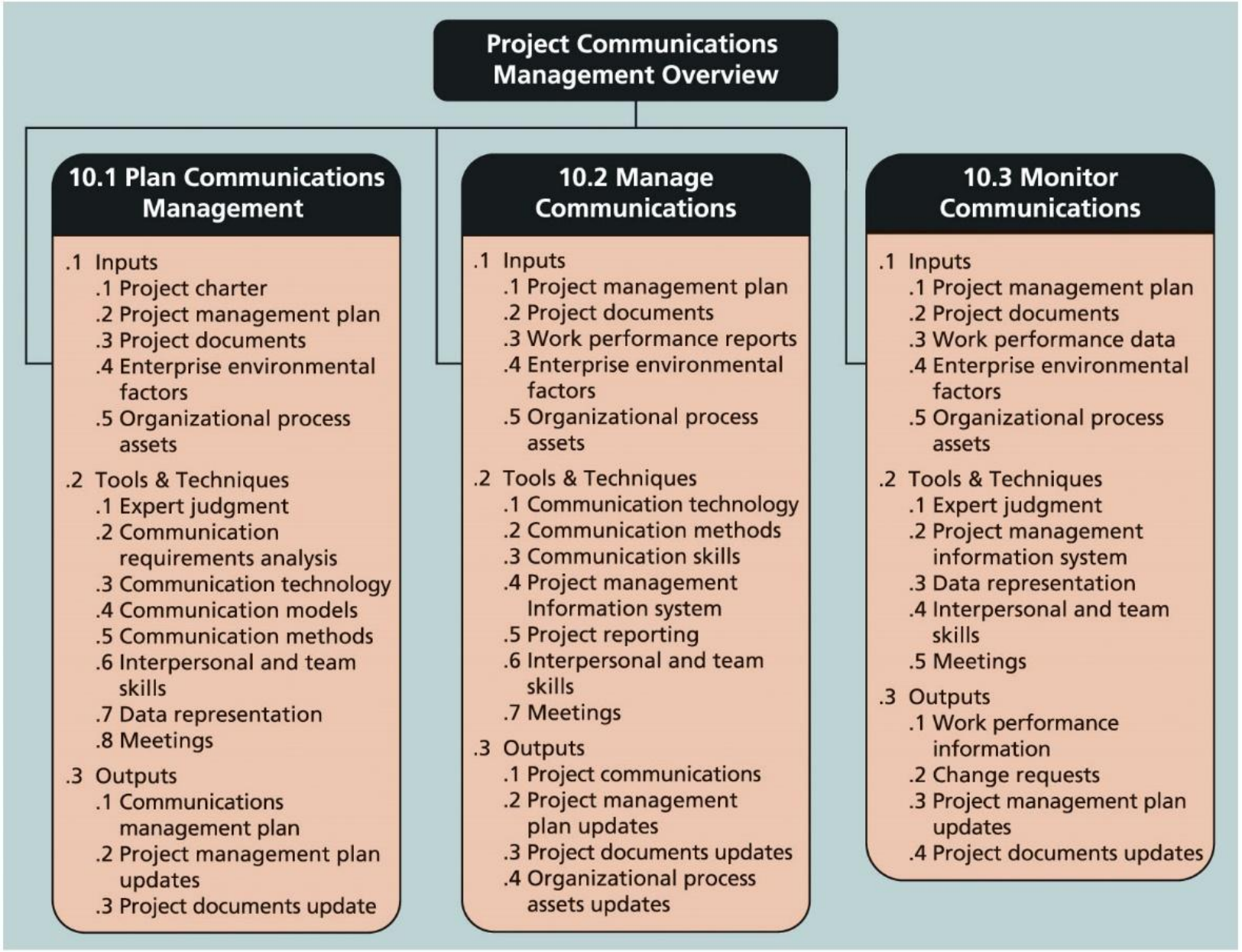




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# Project Communications Management

- Main processes
  1. Planning communications management
     - Determining who needs what information, when they will need it, and how the information will be given to them
  2. Managing communications
     - Creating, distributing, storing, retrieving, and disposing of project communications based on the communications management plan
  3. Monitoring communications
     - Ensuring that stakeholder communication needs are met

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**FIGURE 10-1** Project communications management overview

# 1. Planning Communications Management (1 of 2)

- For small projects, the communications management plan can be part of the team contract/charter
- For large projects, it should be a separate document
- Communications management plan contents
  - Stakeholder communications requirements
  - Information to be communicated, including format, content, and level of detail
  - Who will receive the information and who will produce it
  - Suggested methods or technologies for conveying the information
  - Frequency of communication
  - Escalation procedures for resolving issues
  - Revision procedures for updating the communications management plan
  - A glossary of common terminology

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# Planning Communications Management (2 of 2)

| Stakeholders | Document Name | Document Format | Contact Person | Due |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Customer management | Monthly status report | Hard copy and meeting | Tina Erndt, Tom Silva | First of month |
| Customer business staff | Monthly status report | Hard copy | Julie Grant, Sergey Cristobal | First of month |
| Customer technical staff | Monthly status report | E-mail | Li Chau, Nancy Michaels | First of month |
| Internal management | Monthly status report | Hard copy and meeting | Bob Thomson | First of month |
| Internal business and technical staff | Monthly status report | Intranet | Angie Liu | First of month |
| Training subcontractor | Training plan | Hard copy | Jonathan Kraus | November 1 |
| Software subcontractor | Software implementation plan | E-mail | Najwa Gates | June 1 |

Comments: Put the titles and dates of documents in e-mail headings and have recipients acknowledge receipt.

Table 10-1 Sample stakeholder communications analysis

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# 2. Managing Communications

- Managing communications is a large part of a project manager's job
  - Getting project information to the right people at the right time and in a useful format is just as important as developing the information in the first place
- Important considerations
  - Using technology to enhance information creation and distribution
  - Selecting appropriate communication methods and media
  - Reporting Performance

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# Using Technology to Enhance Creation and Distribution

- Technology can facilitate the process of creating and distributing information, when used effectively, e.g.
  - Email, instant messaging, websites, phones, texting
  - Project management information systems, collaboration tools
  - Audio, video, conference call, video conferencing

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# Selecting the Appropriate Communication Methods and Media

- Classifications for communication methods
  - Interactive communication
    - Two or more people interact to exchange information via meetings, phone calls, or video conferencing
      - Most effective way to ensure common understanding
  - Push communication
    - Information is sent or pushed to recipients without their request via reports, e-mails, faxes, voice mails, and other means
      - Ensures that the information is distributed, but does not ensure that it was received or understood
  - Pull communication
    - Information is sent to recipients at their request via websites, bulletin boards, e-learning, knowledge repositories like blogs, and other means

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**TABLE 10-3** Media choice table

| KEY: 1 = EXCELLENT 2 = ADEQUATE 3 = INAPPROPRIATE | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| How Well Medium Is Suited to: | Hard Copy | Phone Call | Voice Mail | E-mail | Meeting | Web Site |
| Assessing commitment | 3 | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 3 |
| Building consensus | 3 | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 3 |
| Mediating a conflict | 3 | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 3 |
| Resolving a misunderstanding | 3 | 1 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 3 |
| Addressing negative behavior | 3 | 2 | 3 | 2 | 1 | 3 |
| Expressing support/appreciation | 1 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| Encouraging creative thinking | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 3 | 3 |
| Making an ironic statement | 3 | 2 | 2 | 3 | 1 | 3 |
| Conveying a reference document | 1 | 3 | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 |
| Reinforcing one's authority | 1 | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 1 |
| Providing a permanent record | 1 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 3 | 3 |
| Maintaining confidentiality | 2 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 1 | 3 |
| Conveying simple information | 3 | 1 | 1 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| Asking an informational question | 3 | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 | 3 |
| Making a simple request | 3 | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 | 3 |
| Giving complex instructions | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 2 |
| Addressing many people | 2 | 3 or 1* | 2 | 2 | 3 | 1 |

*Depends on system functionality

See Tess Galati, *Email Composition and Communication (EmC2)*. Practical Communications, Inc. (*www.praccom.com*) (2001).

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# Reporting Performance

- Performance reporting keeps stakeholders informed about how resources are being used to achieve project objectives
  - Progress reports describe what the project team has accomplished during a certain period of time
  - Status reports describe where the project stands at a specific point in time
  - Forecasts predict future project status and progress based on past information and trends, e.g. estimate at completion, estimated time to complete, to-complete performance index

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# 3. Monitoring Communications

- Main goal of monitoring communications is to ensure the optimal flow of information throughout the entire project life cycle
  - The project manager and project team should use expert judgment, project management information systems, data representation, interpersonal and team skills, and meetings to assess how well communications are working
  - If problems exist, the project manager and team need to take action, which often requires changes to the earlier processes of planning and managing project communications

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# Suggestions for Improving Project Communications (1 of 2)

- Develop better communication skills
  - Most IT professionals enter the field because of technical skills, while communication skills training is needed
- Run effective meetings
  - Determine if the meeting can be avoided
  - Define the purpose and intended outcome of the meeting
  - Determine who should attend the meeting
  - Provide an agenda to participants before the meeting
  - Prepare handouts and visual aids and make logistical arrangements ahead of time
  - Run the meeting professionally
  - Set the ground rules for the meeting

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# Suggestions for Improving Project Communications (2 of 2)

- Use e-mail and other technologies effectively
  - Be sure to send information to the right people
  - Use meaningful subject lines and limit the content of emails to one main subject
  - Be as clear and concise as possible
  - Reread your e-mail before you send it
  - Limit the number and size of e-mail attachments
  - Delete e-mail that you do not need to save or that does not require a response, e.g. junk mail
  - Make sure the virus protection software is up to date
  - Respond to e-mail quickly
  - If you need to keep e-mail, file each message appropriately
- Employ templates for project communications
  - Providing examples and templates for project communications saves time and money
  - Finding, developing, and sharing relevant templates and sample documents are important tasks for many project managers

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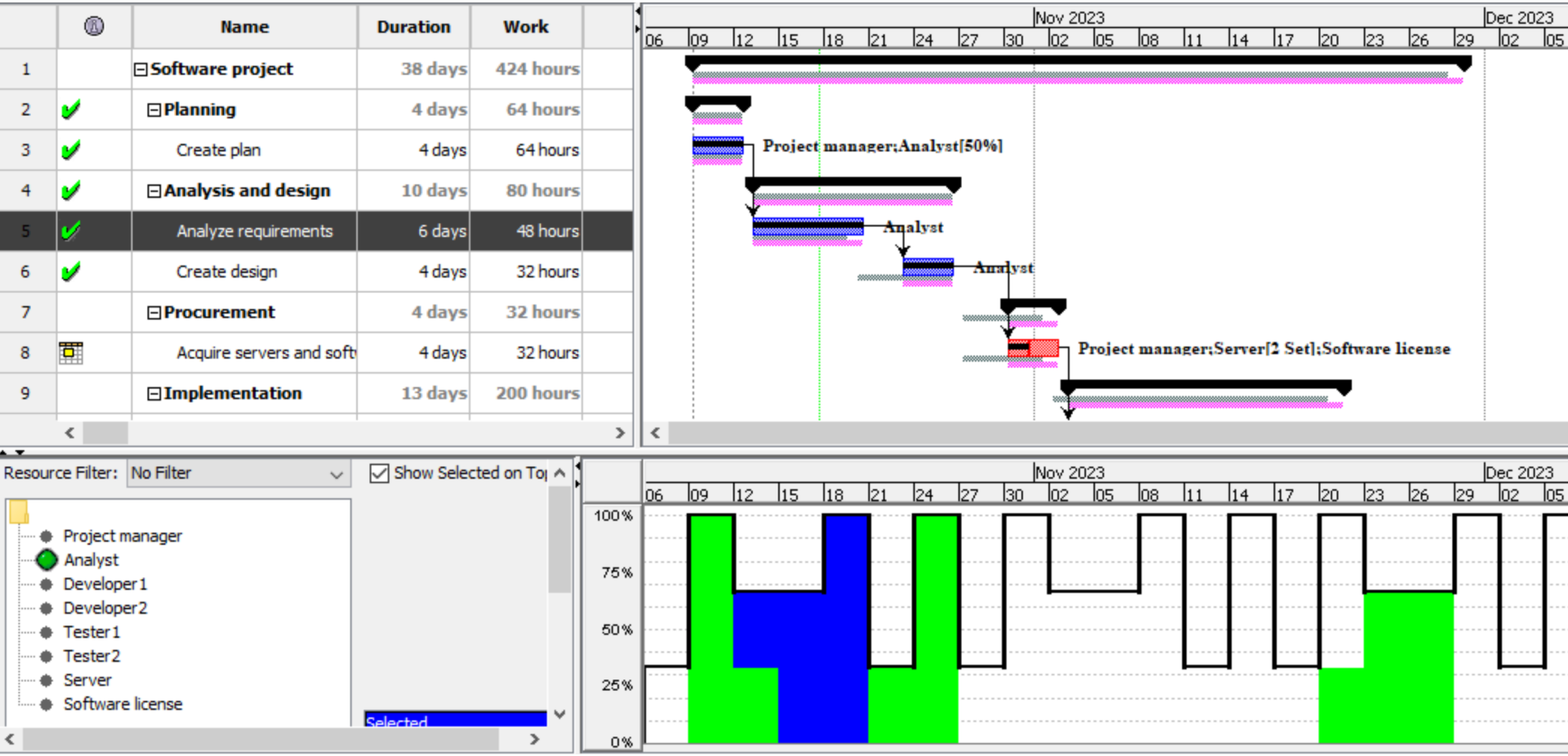
# Using Software to Assist in Project Communications (1 of 5)

- Many organizations are discovering how valuable project management software can be in communicating project information across the organization
  - Project management software can provide different views of information to help meet various communication needs
  - Many project management software products also provide tools to enhance communications
    - Portfolio management
    - Resource management
    - Project collaboration
- Even with all of the technology available, many organizations have problems communicating on global projects
  - Issues with timing, audio, and video
  - Differences in culture and language

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# Using Software to Assist in Project Communications (2 of 5)

Project Management Software

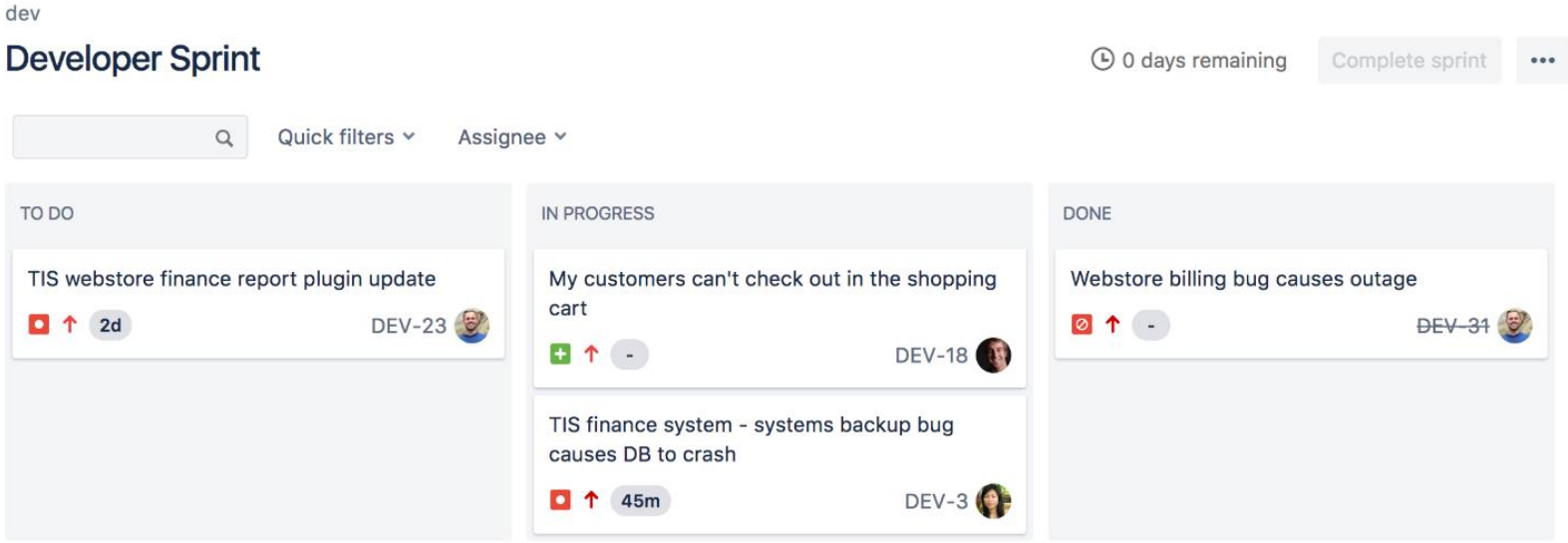



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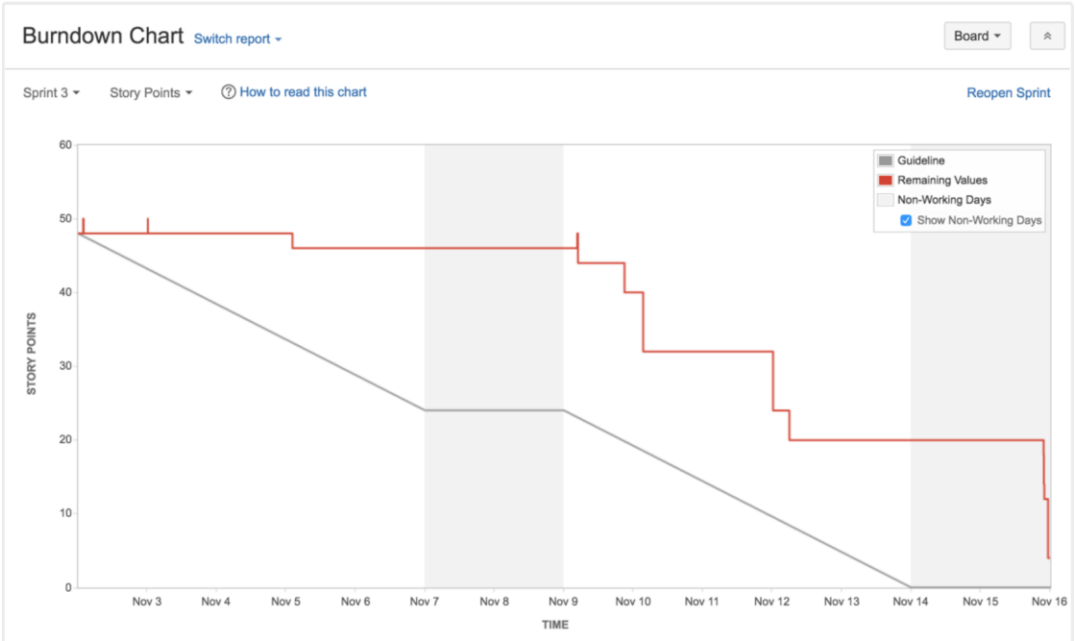
# Using Software to Assist in Project Communications (3 of 5)

Jira Agile Reporting

Scrum Board



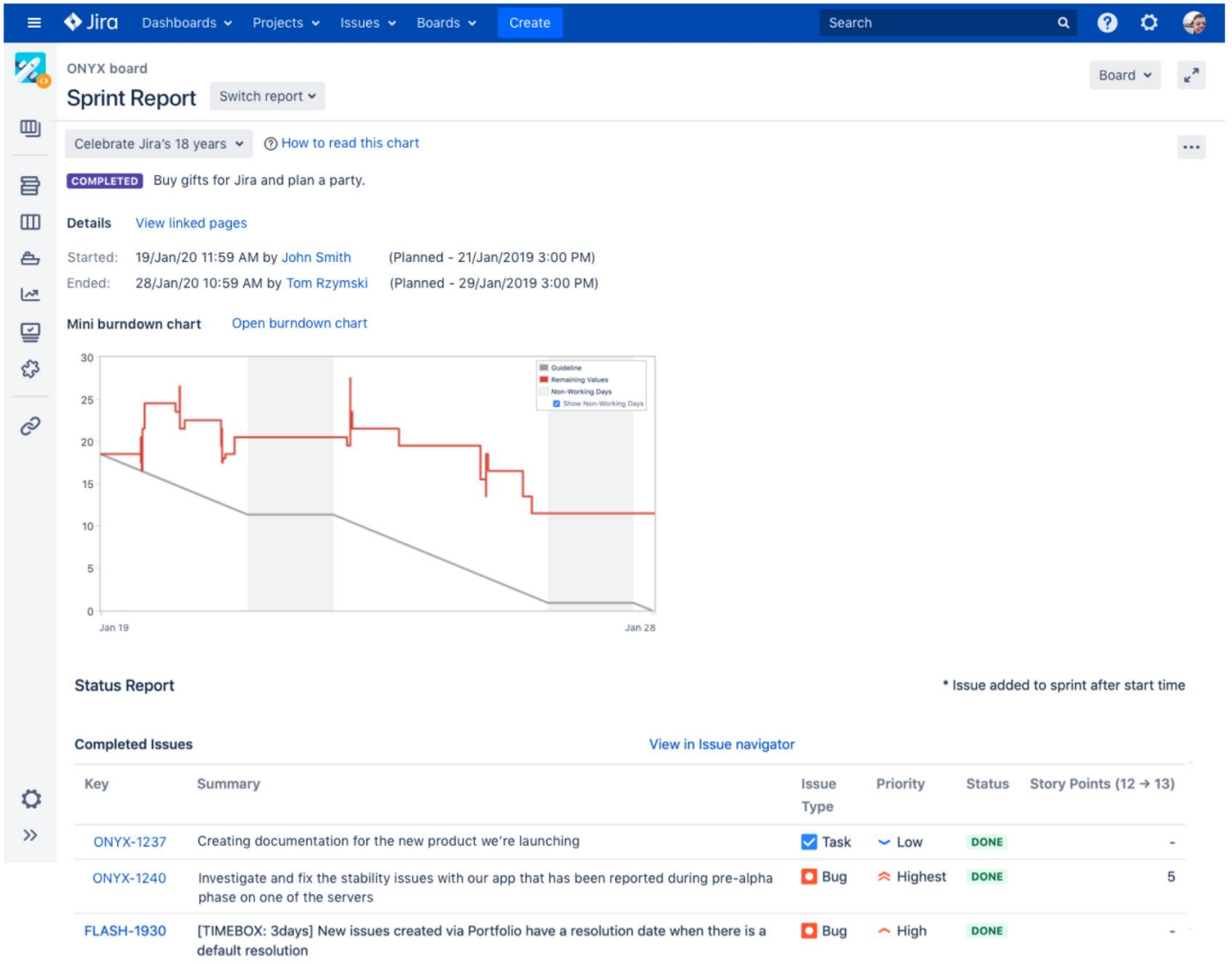

Burndown Chart



# Using Software to Assist in Project Communications (4 of 5)



# Using Software to Assist in Project Communications (5 of 5)




*Screenshot: Sprint Report*

# Considerations For Agile/Adaptive Environments

- Communicating evolving and emerging details frequently
- Streamlining team members to access to information, frequent team checkpoints, and collocating team members
- Holding regular stakeholder reviews promotes communication with management and stakeholders

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# Chapter Summary (1 of 2)

- Failure to communicate is often the greatest threat to the success of any project, especially IT projects
  - Communication is the oil that keeps a project running smoothly
  - Project communications management involves planning communications management, managing communications, and controlling communications
- Project managers can spend as much as 90 percent of their time on communicating
  - There are several keys to good communications
- A communications management plan of some type should be created for all projects to help ensure good communications
  - Contents will vary based on the needs of the project

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# Chapter Summary (2 of 2)

- Managing communication includes creating and distributing project information
  - Various methods for distributing project information include formal, informal, written, and verbal
- To improve project communications, project managers and their teams must develop their communication skills
  - Suggestions for improving project communications include learning how to run more effective meetings, how to use e-mail, instant messaging, texting, kanban boards, and collaborative software more effectively, and how to use templates for project communications
- New hardware and software continue to become available to help improve communications.

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